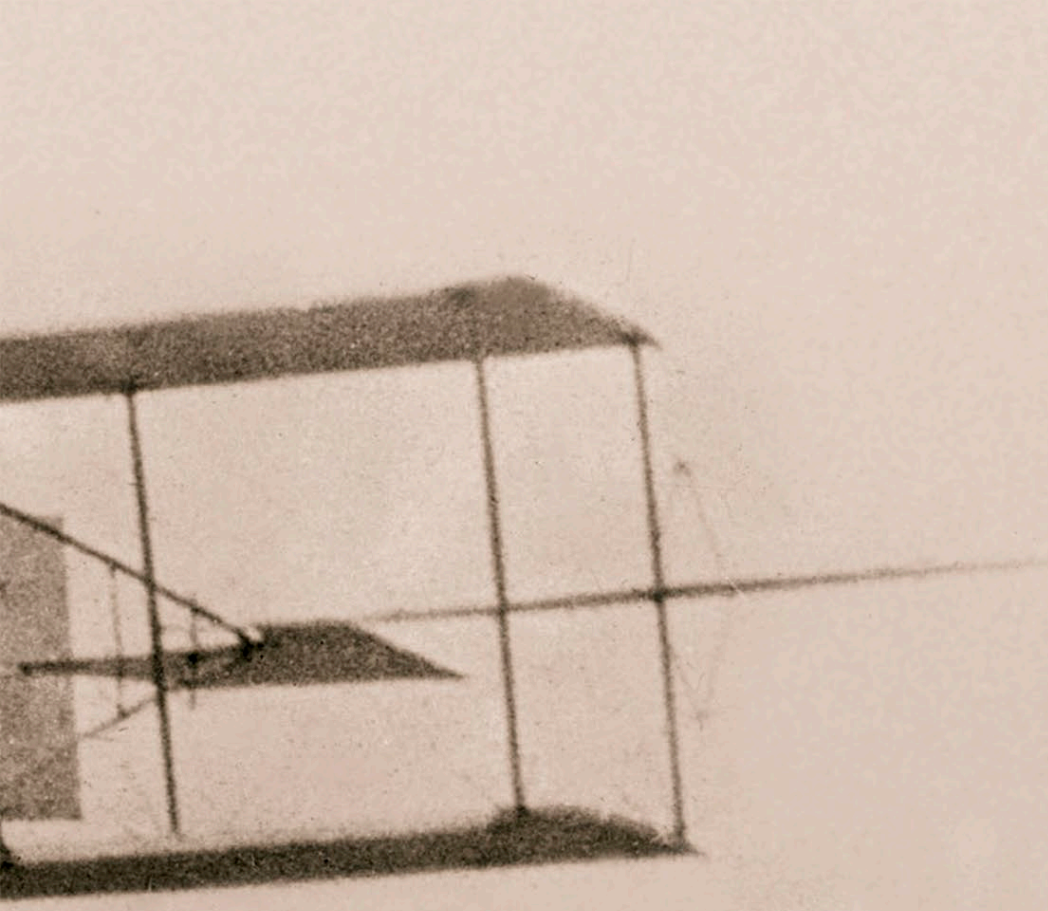




Lincoln Beachey

Regarded as America's greatest early aviator—and the most daring and flamboyant flyer of the period—Lincoln Beachey (1887–1915) first took to the air at the controls of a self-built dirigible. Offering his services to pioneer aircraft builder Glenn Curtiss, the headstrong Beachey refused any form of flight instruction, crashing repeatedly until he learned to master the aircraft. However, it soon became apparent that while he had a colossal ego, the new flyer was a “natural”, who possessed an outstanding feel for the imperfect airplanes of the time. Beachey joined Curtiss's team of exhibition flyers in 1911, inventing the “headless” Model D after a ground accident that smashed the foreplane. Beachey flew the damaged aircraft and found it handled better without the forward surface.

POETRY IN THE AIR

Thomas Edison and Orville Wright were among Beachey's admirers, Wright declaring him “the most wonderful flyer of all.” Beachey did not regard his stunts as reckless; his “Special Looper” biplane was strengthened to cope with aerobatic maneuvers. His last flight in 1915 was intended to be the first demonstration of the vertical “S” in a monoplane. However, while pulling through from inverted, the machine broke up and plummeted into San Francisco Bay, killing Beachey.

Pitting airplane against car in 1914, “Daredevil of the Air” Lincoln Beachey in a “headless” Curtiss Model D races “Demon on the Ground” Barney Oldfield in a front-wheel drive Christie.

